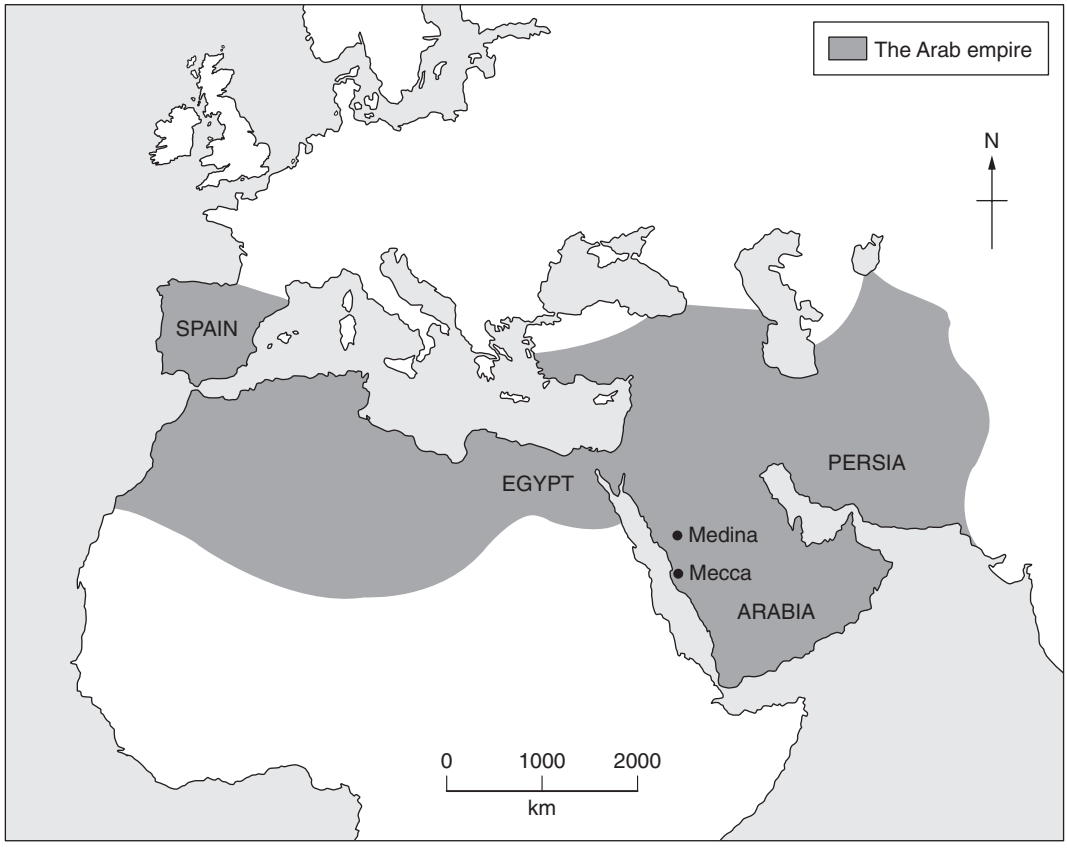


The Arab empire in the eighth century.

Key question
To what extent was the First World War a turning point in the struggle for Arab independence?

The Arabs and the First World War

The First World War was a turning point in the Arab struggle for independence as well as in the Jewish struggle for a homeland. Again it was the British who played a crucial role. Turkey fought on the German side against Britain and its allies. The British were afraid that their supplies of oil from Persia (or Iran as it is known today) might be cut off by the Turks. The British navy was beginning to make more use of oil, as opposed to coal, to fuel its ships at this time. So they decided to encourage the Arabs to rebel against their Turkish rulers and seek independence.

Key term
High Commissioner The most senior diplomat, like an ambassador, representing the British government.

The British **High Commissioner** in Egypt, Sir Herbert McMahon, exchanged several letters with Hussein, the Sharif of Mecca, in 1915. Hussein was Guardian of Mecca and Medina, the two holy sites of Islam (in what is today Saudi Arabia). As such, he was the most important Arab Muslim leader. McMahon promised Hussein that if the Arabs fought against the Turks:

Key date
McMahon–Hussein letters: 1915

> Great Britain is prepared to recognise and support the independence of the Arabs. When the situation allows, Great Britain will assist the Arabs to establish what may appear to be the most suitable forms of government in those various territories.